



Lanka TOURGUIDE

Sri Lanka Travel News

Embracing a Sustainable Future

StarMedia Publication



India leads in Tourist Arrivals

India continues to be the leading source market, with 75,657 arrivals out of 396,274 tourists visited Sri Lanka during the first 15 days of October, achieving 1,801,151 for the year.

இலங்கை சுற்றுலா
பரவலாகி வருவதை
இந்தியாவிலிருந்து
பromotion
for 3 weeks
Oct13 - Nov2
at Barbeque Nation,
Colombo City Centre



FEEL AN AMAZING EXPERIENCE AT IMMERSIVE 7DEGREE IN COLOMBO

Immerse in a fully immersive experience, so expected to be "transported to a different world" through the advanced technology used at a unique, immersive dining experience in Colombo. Visit Sri Lanka's first Immersive Restaurant, 7Degrees, which uses projectors, sensors, and Dolby Atmos sound to create a multi-sensory culinary journey for a small group. This fine-dining experience is designed by the renowned hospitality expert Nalin Malwenna, Managing Director of H.O.T. Travels.

Executive Chef Patrick Velans offers a captivating blend of technology and gourmet cuisine, with themes that change to transport diners to different worlds.

You can expect a unique experience at Immerse, with a multi-sensory journey. Immerse goes beyond typical dining by engaging all your senses through visual, auditory, and olfactory elements.

The high-tech advanced technology provides the space equipped with projectors, sensors, and a Dolby Atmos sound system to create dynamic environments. You can also enjoy themed experiences with multi-course menu curated to fit a changing theme for the evening, with each dish presented alongside its own audio-visual display to enhance the experience.

The restaurant will accommodate a limited number of guests, making it a unique and exclusive experience. If you wish to experience this exceptional opportunity make a reservation any day of the week by calling +94 112 559 222. 7Dedree Immerse is located at No.270, Park Road, Colombo 05.

Considerations for a First-Time Experience, given its unique nature and limited capacity, booking your spot in advance is much better.

Communicate Your Occasion:

If you're planning a special event, such as a proposal, note that the restaurant can play your own photos and videos upon request.



Experience Luxury and Elegance where every meal is a Culinary Masterpiece

Enjoy the Sri Lanka's first immersive dining experience, from dining in the cosmos among Galaxies to being Underwater, Immerse takes you on a Multi-sensory journey.

It's Unique!

Twist to Colombo's Landscape to enjoy food and beverages. Come for the vibes, stay for the spice. Come, dream, and dine with us!

Host your Corporate Sessions, Business Meetings, Client Entertainment, Staff Gatherings, Friends & Family, for Parties, GTG and Private Dining

in a dedicated space for couples & small groups

7 Degrees Immersive Restaurant
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Colombo 05. Sri Lanka
Ph: +9411 255 9222

Open Hours:
Monday – Sunday
3 pm to 12 Midnight
Happy Hours:
Monday – Friday | 5 to 8 pm

Treat Clients, Staff, Friends & Family to a unique dining experience in Colombo

"More than a meal; it's an atmosphere you can taste."

7degrees.lk | <https://7degrees.lk>

October 2025



Hospitality leaders applaud the launch

The hospitality industry holds the TOURGUIDE magazine in high esteem

Sri Lanka's first periodical publication to promote sustainable tourism — TOURGUIDE print & online magazine that launched last month in Sri Lanka have been met with praise from both the hospitality sector and tourists. The publication is valued for showcasing the country's diverse tourist attractions and providing essential information that is both helpful to visitors and helps promote Sri Lanka as a premier destination.

"This is a commendable and timely initiative to launch a travel magazine in Sri Lanka, especially one focused on promoting sustainable tourism. It addresses the nation's need for a balanced approach to tourism development, ensuring economic growth is compatible with environmental protection and socio-cultural preservation, particularly in the face of current challenges. Your magazine will be a valuable platform for educating both locals and international tourists on responsible practices and promoting alternative, lesser-known destinations that can help alleviate pressure on popular sites.

With Sri Lanka's tourism sector growing, there is an increasing need to balance economic benefits with environmental and social well-being. The magazine's focus on sustainability directly supports this critical requirement" said Upali Ratnayake former Deputy Director General of Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority.

Suresh Abbas, General Manager said it is very important to promote responsible travel by highlighting responsible practices, the magazine can inspire travelers to make more conscious choices, thereby minimizing negative impacts on the environment and local communities.

Onitha Gurugalla, Associate Director PR Taj Hotels noted about diversified tourist offerings. She said the initiative helps promote lesser-known regions and experiences, which can lead to a more even distribution of tourism and reduce overcrowding in popular areas.

"A dedicated magazine serves as a vital tool for educating both domestic and international audiences about the importance of sustainable tourism and the specific initiatives happening in Sri Lanka. By focusing on sustainable and responsible practices, the magazine can help build a more resilient tourism sector that can withstand future challenges, as seen with the impacts of the pandemic and the economic crisis" said Nalin Malwenna Managing Director H.O.T. Tourism (Pvt) Ltd.

Features in TOURGUIDE will include stories on eco-lodges, community-based tourism projects, conservation efforts, and responsible travel tips. The distribution plan to include international airlines and key tourist markets will ensure the message reaches a global audience. StarMedia will closely work with Organizations like the UNDP, Green Destinations, Intrepid Travel, Solidaridad Network, Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority and Sri Lanka Tourism Promotions Bureau to align with national strategies and tap into existing resources.



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TOURISM JOURNALISTS' ALLIANCE





The Fortress Resort & Spa

*Your Coastal
Sanctuary in Southern
Sri Lanka*



Along Sri Lanka's sun-kissed southern coast, where the sea meets centuries of history, stands The Fortress Resort & Spa, a haven that redefines boutique coastal luxury. Inspired by the architecture of a Dutch fort and the warmth of Sri Lankan hospitality, The Fortress seamlessly blends heritage, design and contemporary comfort, offering guests an experience that feels as timeless as the tides themselves.

Located in Koggala, just minutes from the iconic Galle Fort, the resort captures the essence of the region's calm, cultured and elegant charm. Its distinctive façade, reminiscent of a grand coastal citadel, opens into tranquil courtyards, lush gardens and open corridors where ocean breezes whisper through the air. Every element, from the architecture to the art, celebrates a deep connection to the region and an unwavering attention to detail. The resort's 55 rooms and suites embody understated sophistication. Each is designed as a private retreat, with soothing tones, luxurious amenities, and terraces that frame sweeping views of the Indian Ocean or the surrounding greenery. At the heart of the resort lies Spa Naturel, a haven of Ayurveda and wellness that restores harmony between soul, body and mind. Treatments are customised through individual consultations and feature locally sourced herbs and botanicals in therapies that balance ancient wisdom, authentic elements and modern comfort. Combined with yoga sessions



by the sea, it's an experience of holistic wellness that embodies serenity and renewal unlike any other.

Dining at The Fortress is a sensory celebration of flavour and craft. The Terrace, the resort's signature restaurant, presents a diverse dining repertoire where contemporary international cuisine meets the vibrant essence of Sri Lankan culinary tradition. 'Itameshi' (Italian food) excites the palate with a creative fusion of Japanese precision and Italian flair, while Time Out Bar invites guests to unwind with handcrafted cocktails and fine wines that complement the soft glow of southern sunsets. Every flavour, every detail and every gesture reflect The Fortress's enduring dedication to thoughtful, heartfelt hospitality.

Beyond its walls, guests can discover the coastal wonders of the south, from whale watching and turtle hatchery visits to tea plantation tours and the historic streets of Galle Fort. Each experience is curated to reflect the island's spirit: vibrant, generous and full of life. Celebrated across global hospitality circles, The Fortress Resort & Spa stands today as one of Sri Lanka's finest boutique properties, where history and modernity coexist, and every stay becomes a story worth telling.

The Fortress Resort & Spa, located in Koggala along Sri Lanka's southern coast, is a boutique luxury property that combines Dutch colonial-inspired architecture with contemporary design and premium amenities. The resort features 53 rooms and suites, three dining venues, and Spa Naturel, an Ayurvedic wellness centre offering holistic treatments. Positioned near the UNESCO World Heritage Site of Galle Fort, The Fortress provides a distinctive blend of coastal tranquility, modern comfort and personalised service, catering to both leisure and business travellers.

Enjoy Swedish Food at London Grill



Chef Carola Magnusson with GM Nazoomi Azhar



The celebration continues on 4th October, when Cinnamon Grand's Tea Lounge marks International Cinnamon Bun Day with a live Swedish Cinnamon Bun action station, personally inspired by Chef Carola's recipes. Guests can savour warm, cardamom-spiced buns fresh from the oven, alongside the hotel's indulgent special high tea buffet, a charming nod to Sweden's sweetest tradition.

Cinnamon Colombo Hotels is located in the heart of the city, Cinnamon Lakeside Colombo offers tranquil getaways in its unique offering of a 'Resort in the City' with expansive lakefront and garden views. Unveiling elegance and grandeur is Colombo's most luxurious, modern, and truly 'grand' city hotels, Cinnamon Grand Colombo, located near Colombo's Galle Face Green, overlooking views of the majestic Indian Ocean and upcoming Port City. Completing the Colombo city collection is the first of its kind in South Asia, Cinnamon Red Colombo. Walking distance to shopping centers, historical sites and nightlife precincts of Colombo, this pioneering addition to the Cinnamon Colombo Hotel collection embodies the 'Lean Luxury' concept. Inspired by the arts and modern design, panoramas of Colombo's cityscape and of course the innovative food and beverage options within the property, Cinnamon Red is the popular choice for urbanites and tech enthused travelers.

A Taste of Sweden with Chef Carola Magnusson at London Grill a special culinary promotion at Cinnamon Grand Colombo as part of London Grill's 50th anniversary celebrations, where Nordic Flavours Meet Timeless Elegance.

Renowned Swedish chef and Founder & CEO of Carolas Eko, Chef Carola Magnusson, will present a refined Swedish à la carte menu at London Grill, featuring authentic Nordic flavours from October 2 - 5. Cinnamon Grand Colombo brings the spirit of Scandinavia to the city as part of the grand 50th anniversary celebration of its signature London Grill. Chef Magnusson, well known in Sweden for her commitment to wholesome, sustainable cooking and her flair for combining tradition with innovation, the Chef brings her philosophy to Colombo in two exciting culinary experiences. Together, these experiences not only highlight her culinary artistry but also honour the London Grill's remarkable five-decade legacy as Colombo's most enduring fine dining destination.

The celebrations will also include a Swedish Cinnamon Bun action station at the Cinnamon Grand Tea Lounge on 4 of International Cinnamon Bun Day, paired with indulgent high tea buffet with a curated authentic Swedish menu along with the beloved tradition of freshly baked cinnamon buns. Cinnamon Roll Day or Cinnamon Bun Day falls on Saturday October 4.

Sweden Chef will present a refined à la carte menu featuring dishes that reflect the soul of Swedish cuisine. Among the highlights are the classic Swedish Skagen on sourdough crostini, her refreshing Jerusalem Artichoke Soup, the comforting Moose Meatballs with lingonberries and potato-celeriac purée, and the delicately balanced Salt Cured Sea bass Fillet with white wine sauce and trout roe. Each dish is a tribute to the purity and elegance of Nordic gastronomy.



Each dish is a tribute to the purity and elegance of Nordic Gastronomy.

UN TOURISM CELEBRATES WORLD TOURISM DAY 2025 IN MALAYSIA A Milestone for Sustainable Transformation

September 27, 2025.



Malaysia's Minister of Tourism, Arts and Culture



United Nations Secretary-General



UN Tourism Secretary-General



Deputy Prime Minister of Malaysia

UN Tourism celebrated World Tourism Day 2025 in the historic city of Melaka, Malaysia, under the theme **"Tourism and Sustainable Transformation."** This global day of recognition for the sector and its vital importance marked a pivotal moment in advancing tourism as a catalyst for positive change, resilience, and sustainable development worldwide. The celebrations, brought together global leaders, policymakers, industry experts, and local communities to share innovative ideas and chart a sustainable future for the tourism sector, aligned with the 7th edition of the World Tourism Conference (WTC), showcasing Malaysia's rich cultural heritage, breathtaking landscapes, and commitment to sustainable tourism.

This year's theme underscored tourism's potential to drive social progress, economic growth, and environmental stewardship. The event highlighted the need for good governance, strategic planning, and inclusive policies to ensure tourism benefits all while preserving cultural and natural heritage. **Malaysia's Minister of Tourism, Arts and Culture, H.E. Dato Sri Tiong King Sing**, welcomed participants from around the world to Melaka at the opening of World Tourism Day 2025 and the 7th World Tourism Conference.

United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres emphasized, "Tourism is a powerful driver of transformation. It creates jobs, fuels local economies, and builds bridges across cultures. Yet, it must be sustainable to protect the very places and communities it celebrates. Let's harness tourism as a force for resilience, sustainability, and shared progress."

UN Tourism Secretary-General Zurab Pololikashvili added, "World Tourism Day 2025 in Melaka has shown the world that tourism can be a force for good when guided by sustainability and inclusivity. By working together, we can transform tourism into a tool for empowerment, cultural preservation, and environmental protection."

By working together, we can transform tourism into a tool for empowerment, cultural preservation, and environmental protection. **Highlights of World Tourism Day 2025** Affirming this commitment, the **Deputy Prime Minister of Malaysia, The Right Honourable Dato' Sri Haji Fadillah bin Yusof**, on behalf of the Prime Minister of Malaysia, officiated the opening of World Tourism Day 2025 and the 7th World Tourism Conference in Melaka.

Highlighting tourism's role as a unifying force, he stressed that growth must be inclusive and

resilient, underpinned by sustainability, innovation, and global cooperation. He also outlined Malaysia's initiatives – from expanding high-value tourism segments and digital nomad hubs, to investments in sustainable aviation fuel and community-led ecotourism – as examples of balancing economic progress with social and environmental responsibility. He also announced that Malaysia will join the UN Tourism International Network of Sustainable Tourism Observatories (INSTO) with a pilot project in Mersing, Johor.

The celebrations featured a series of activities, including high-level panel discussions and cultural showcases focused on sustainable tourism practices and innovative strategies geared towards the resilience of the tourism industry. The focus was placed on building sustainable transformation through Investing in Education and Skills: Programmes to empower women, youth, and marginalized communities through tourism-related training and employment opportunities.

Accelerating innovation and digital transformation: Identifying tourism game-changers, including entrepreneurs, innovators and start-ups and supporting them to transform ideas into action and scale-up. Investing in digital education and closing the 'digital gap' through empowering rural communities, youth and post-conflict societies.

Supporting Local Economies: Promoting micro, small, and medium-sized enterprises to ensure tourism benefits reach local communities.

Cultural Exchange: Showcasing Malaysia's vibrant heritage through performances, culinary experiences, and exhibitions, reinforcing tourism's role in preserving traditions.

World Tourism Conference 2025: A Framework for Collaboration Held in the framework of World Tourism Day, the 7th edition of the World Tourism Conference (WTC) in Melaka served as a platform for fostering stronger bonds and innovative ideas for the global tourism industry.

The conference brought together stakeholders to discuss strategies for sustainable tourism development, focusing on resilience, inclusivity, and environmental stewardship. Key sessions explored topics such as digital transformation in tourism, community-based tourism models, and climate-neutral travel solutions, aligning with the theme "Tourism and Sustainable Transformation."

Take a look at the unforgettable moments from a Thai culinary journey, where the vibrant aromas, spices, and colors of Thailand came alive in Colombo. ✨

The "A Voyage of Thai Flavours" festival at Hilton Colombo Residences ran from October 2–16, (2025) a two-week celebration of Thailand's rich gastronomy at the FLOW restaurant. The event featured guest chefs Natkon (Moo) and Amonrat (Orr) from the DoubleTree by Hilton Phuket Banthai Resort offering guests an unforgettable journey through Thailand's most cherished flavours and traditions. From timeless favorites to signature creations, Chefs Moo and Orr delighted guests with an authentic taste of Thailand.

The buffet celebrated the heart of Thailand's culinary heritage offering an authentic Thai buffet with dishes like Green Curry and Mango Sticky Rice with Thai Spicy Grilled Corn Salad, Phuket Pineapple Fried Rice, and Beverages including a Free-flow house with special cocktails and mocktails and was priced at Rs. 7,800 nett per person. Each evening, FLOW transformed into a showcase of Thailand's finest flavours, bringing together traditional recipes and regional specialties. Guests discovered a colourful array of dishes prepared with fragrant herbs, fresh produce, and bold spices, with highlights such as tum khao pod, gai yang hat yai, gaeng kiew wan gai, khao pad sapparot goong, and the much-loved khao niew mamuang. Guests commended that it was a more than just the buffet, with live cooking stations bringing the sizzle of Thai kitchens to life, street food favourites served fresh with authentic flair, and an endless pour of house-crafted cocktails



Hilton Colombo Residences General Manager Karim Schadlou with Paitoon Mahapanaporn, Ambassador of Thailand to Sri Lanka. Both Thai Chefs and Zafita Kareem, Travel Editor of The Island is also in the picture.

and mocktails. Together, these elements create a festive dining experience that captures the vibrancy and charm of Thailand's culinary spirit. Hilton Colombo Residences General Manager Karim Schadlou said, "we are delighted to host 'A Voyage of Thai Flavours' at Hilton Colombo Residences. This event is a celebration of Thailand's rich culinary traditions, and we are honoured to welcome two exceptionally talented chefs from DoubleTree by Hilton Phuket Banthai Resort. Their creativity and dedication to authentic Thai cuisine will ensure a truly memorable experience for all our guests."

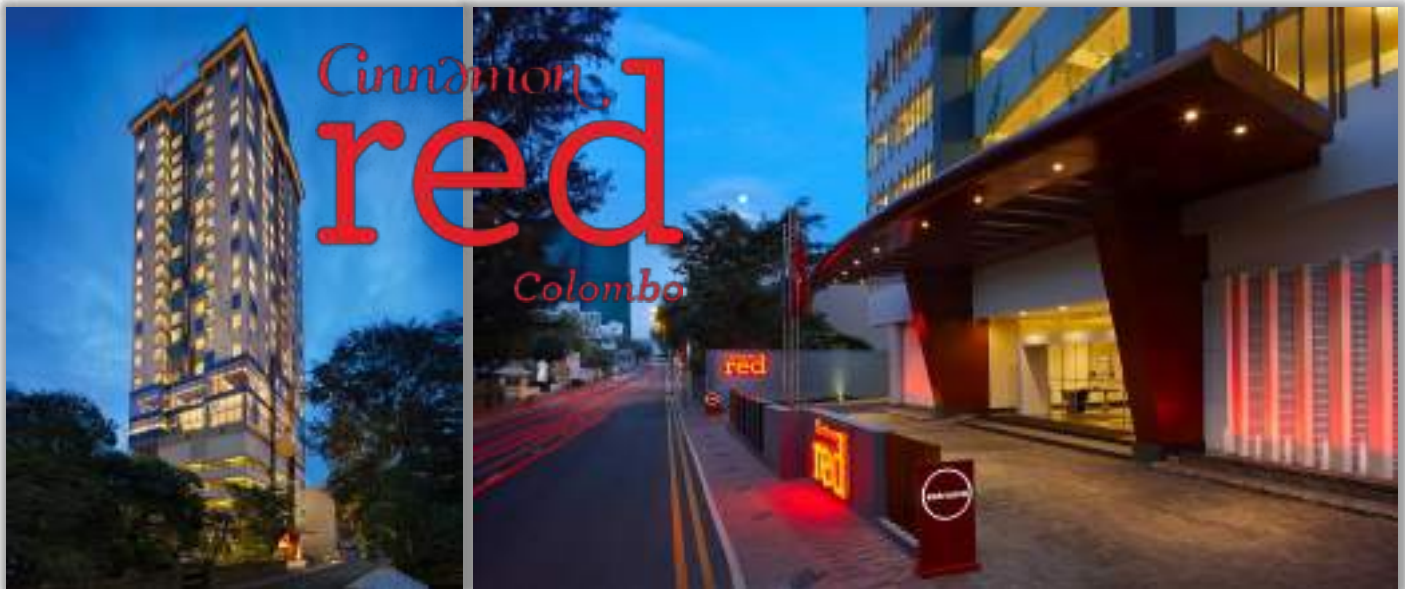


VOYAGE OF THAI FLAVOURS' AT HILTON COLOMBO RESIDENCES

Anusha Maureen



An experience of tasting the essence of Thai in every dish



A great 'Sleep Night' beyond the bedroom

by Anusha Maureen

It is said that "Once you are in Colombo, you are not a visitor anymore, but a part of it". The phrase suggests that arriving in Colombo allows you to become integrated into the city's life and energy. This embodies Cinnamon Red Colombo, a "youthful and vibrant city hotel" that provides the means to assimilate into the city's rhythms as designed for curious travelers, not just tourists.

The hotel's concept of "lean luxury" provides essential amenities and a comfortable stay while focusing on the modern and energetic spirit of exploring the city, placing you at the center of Colombo's activity rather than just observing it from the outside. The property is designed for travelers who want essential luxury without extravagance. It features modern rooms, and many of them offer city and sea views, which can enhance the overall experience and contribute to a pleasant stay.

Cinnamon Red Colombo is a chic and contemporary hotel that brings a new level of modernity and style to Sri Lanka's capital. Amidst the crowded city of Colombo 'Cinnamon Red Colombo' the youthful and vibrant modern city hotel where guests can experience an excellent sleep night. Cinnamon Red Colombo is described as a stylish and comfortable city hotel that offers a great value for money.



Terrence Fernando, General Manager of Cinnamon Red, describes the hotel as a successful "lean luxury" hotel that provides a 5-star sleeping experience through technology and modern flair at an affordable price. He highlights the hotel's innovative business model, efficient staff-to-room ratio, and dedication to guest satisfaction, while also acknowledging the challenge of continuously raising standards to maintain its unique market position.

"At Cinnamon Red Colombo, we prioritise your comfort, whether it's for a relaxing break, a productive work trip, or a special celebration. From the moment you check in, our ambience and service ensure that every experience is memorable and tailored to your needs. Trust us to create a perfect harmony of comfort and hospitality throughout your stay. Mr. Fernando says, "Our warmth, hospitality and friendliness are repeatedly mention in reviews. My gratitude to the whole staff for maintaining excellently".

The property offers 243 smart and comfortable rooms, and is known for its vibrant atmosphere breathtaking views often with city and ocean views and providing convenience and easy access to city points of interest. The property is a modern, minimalist design located in the city. The hotel offers a unique concept of "lean luxury," focusing on essential comforts without a fuss, making it a good value for money. The hotel as centrally located provides easy access to all city attractions, famous shops, and important government and international offices. A popular convenient store Keells Super is just a short walk from the hotel.

Guests frequently praise Cinnamon Red's rooms for being modern, spacious, clean, and comfortable, often highlighting the great city views and well-maintained cleanliness. They acclaim the hotel's immaculate and comfortable rooms with comfortable beds, making for a restful night. They appreciate the comfortable beds, modern amenities, and the quality of housekeeping such as daily room maintenance to a high standard, contributes to guest comfort and satisfaction. The inclusion of soundproof rooms provides a quiet environment conducive to a good sleep.

Many guests' reviews are positive. They describe the cozy rooms as charming modern, and well-equipped. They also comment positively about the cleanliness and the well-maintenance by the housekeeping staff. Guests frequently mention the excellent city views from the rooms and thoughtful amenities contributing to a relaxing stay. Guests frequently commend the staff for being polite, professional, and always willing to assist, with delighted services and warm atmosphere to stay again.

Being a Travel Writer of Lanka TOURGUIDE, I can attest to the truth and accuracy of these guest remarks from my own experience as I had a good night sleep at Cinnamon Red. Yes, of course rooms offer "epic" and "breathtaking" panoramic views of the city skyline and the Indian Ocean through the windows and rooms provide essentials, luxury elements such as a comfortable king-size bed, fresh linen, and high-quality washrooms with a modern shower experience, finally a tranquil bedroom for optimal sleep environment. Guests also consistently praise the staff for being helpful and pleasant. The staff are described as friendly, youthful, and welcoming, providing a high level of hospitality. Guests highlight the pleasant and helpful attitude of the hotel staff from top to bottom stems from a culture of guest satisfaction where every employee, from management to front-line staff, demonstrates professionalism, a positive demeanor, excellent communication, and a willingness to go the extra mile to anticipate and meet guest needs. This shows the strong leadership, ongoing training, clear service standards, and a focus on teamwork, creating a welcoming and memorable experience for guests.

The hotel's focus on quality, combined with amenities like an infinity rooftop pool and well-regarded breakfast options, positions it as a great opportunity for a satisfying stay in Colombo. The rooftop infinity pool and bar called Cloud Red, is a popular spot for guests to relax and take in the scenery. The pool offers stunning city views, especially during sunsets. The breakfast buffet is noted for its Western good variety, including guests choices such as Sri Lankan, Indian, Chinese, Western etcetera.



Experience nuanced comfort and spacious interiors as you watch the bustling city through the window.



6 Golds. 2 Silvers. One Destination Expert



Sri Lanka triumphed at the South Asian Travel Awards



Ms. Onitha Gurugalla, Associate Director PR, Taj Lanka Hotels receiving the award from Ismail Hameed President of SATA.

(By Claude Gunasekera, Media Coordinator)

The 9th edition of South Asian Travel Awards (SATA) 2025 was held in Colombo last week, Sri Lanka being the destination partner. Sri Lanka won the best of Gold Awards as most Desirable Island at the Wanderlust Travel Awards of the South Asian Region, SATA' the South Asian Travel Awards. These award signifies the highest level of recognition for Sri Lanka tourism industry to show such a remarkable recovery, reaching even the one-million visitor milestone faster than in previous years, with the "Year of Tourism Revival" declared for 2025.

The gala event held in collaboration with Sri Lanka Tourism Promotion Bureau and Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority while Cinnamon Grand Colombo was the official host. SATA President Ismail Hameed told 'Lanka TouGuide' that purpose of the event is to celebrate innovation and service excellence in the travel, tourism, and hospitality industry across South Asia. "This year's gala brought together distinguished guests, eminent tourism authorities, esteemed partners, and industry leaders from across the region. Against the vibrant backdrop of Sri Lanka's culture and heritage, the evening celebrated South Asia's collective spirit of hospitality and innovation" told Hameed.

In a night of recognition and inspiration Sri Lanka won 10 SATA Gold Awards. 53 Gold Award winners and 113 Silver Award winners were honored across diverse categories, showcasing the very best of Sri Lanka, India, Maldives, Nepal, Bhutan, and Bangladesh. The winners embody not only service excellence and innovation but also the resilience and unity that continue to elevate South Asia's tourism industry to global prominence. The Visitors' Choice Awards, reflecting the voice of global travelers, were

among the most anticipated recognitions of the evening. This year's winners included Sri Lanka as the leading MICE & Wellness Destination. Leading Adventure Destination – Maldives, Leading Heritage Destination – Bhutan.

2025 Gold Awards honored the finest in South Asian hospitality, travel, and aviation. Sri Lanka celebrated several essential triumphs with Cinnamon Hotels and Resorts, Aitken Spence Travels & Heritance Hotels, Hayleys Travels, Shangri-La Colombo, Amaya Resorts, Royal Palms, Tharu Villas Villu, Theva Residency, Occidental Eden, W15 Collection, Fox Jaffna, Club Dolphin, Mandarin Colombo, Smooth Flight Support and SriLankan Airlines. The top Gold Awards in the South Asian region were awarded to Sri Lanka for their excellent performance. Aitken Spence Travels as Leading Travel Agent – Inbound, Hayleys Travels (Pvt) Ltd as Leading Travel Agent – Outbound. Shangri-La Colombo as Leading Luxury Hotel, Heritance Ayurveda as Leading Wellness & Spa Hotel/Resort, Marine Bay Colombo as Leading City Hotel (40 Rooms below) while SriLankan Airlines was awarded the Leading International Airline in the South Asian region. The Marvel Sri Lanka Adventures & Expeditions (Pvt) Ltd was awarded for Best Promotion Campaign.

A key highlight of the evening was the conferral of the SATA – Faces of South Asia, a tribute to visionary leaders who's lifelong contributions have shaped the region's tourism and hospitality landscape. This year's honorees were Deshamanya D. Harry S. Jayawardena – Chairman Emeritus, Aitken Spence PLC, Sri Lanka, Nandini Lahe-Thapa – Retired Senior Director, Nepal Tourism Board, Nepal, Jyoti Mayal – Former President, Travel Agents Association of India (TAAI) India, Mohamed Waheeduddeen – Chairman,

Bandos Island Resort, Republic of Maldives. Kamal Munasinghe, Chief Operating Officer of Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts and former General Manager of Cinnamon Grand Colombo Sri Lanka won the best GM Gold Award while Ahmed Zahir, Angsana Velavaru Maldives, Digvijay Singh, Conrad Bengaluru India (South), Karthi VK, Holiday Inn Express Kathmandu Naxal Nepal and Khagendra Dahal, Hotel Tashi Yid - Wong Grand Bhutan also won best GM Gold Awards for their respective countries.

The Maldives received the Leading Luxury Resort: The Ritz-Carlton Maldives, Fari Islands. Most Romantic Resort: You & Me Maldives, Leading All-Inclusive Resort: Heritance Aarah, Maldives, Leading Tourist Transport Provider (Air): Trans Maldivian Airways (Pvt) Ltd, Maldives.

Leading Heritage Hotel/Resort: Zhiwaling Heritage, Bhutan and South Asia's Best New Hotel/Resort: Hilton Kathmandu, Nepal.

Leading City Hotel (40 Rooms above): Sheraton Grand Bangalore at Brigade Gateway India (South).

RIU Hotels won Gold for Leading Resort/Hotel Brand, Sarangkot Mountain Lodge Nepal as Leading Hill Resort/Hotel, Cinnamon Lodge Habarana Sri Lanka as Leading Eco-Friendly Hotel/Resort, Amaya Lake Sri Lanka as Leading Family Hotel/Resort, You & Me Maldives as Most Romantic Resort, Aabas Pokhara Nepal as Leading Guest House/Tourist Inn, Cinnamon Velifushi Maldives as Leading Beach Resort, Baymaas Lakehouse India (South) as Leading Boutique Hotel/Resort, Leading Budget Hotel Accord Chrome India (South) as Leading Luxury Hotel, Shangri-La Colombo Sri Lanka as Leading Luxury Resort, The Ritz-Carlton, Fari Islands Maldives as Leading Luxury Hotel, Cinnamon Lakeside Colombo Sri Lanka as Leading Wedding Hotel, The Kingsbury Colombo Sri Lanka as Leading F&B Hotel/Resort, Ceylon Extreme Adventures (Pvt) Ltd Sri Lanka as Leading Adventure/Sports Tour Operator, Best Dives (Pvt) Ltd Maldives as Leading Dive Center.

Following Gold awards were also offered to Nishan Seneviratne Best CSR Programme to The Peninsula Chittagong PLC Bangladesh, South Asia's Best New Hotel/Resort to Hilton Kathmandu Nepal, Leading Heritage Hotel/Resort to Zhiwaling Heritage Bhutan, Leading Meeting and Conference Hotel/Resort to Shangri-La Colombo Sri Lanka, Leading All-inclusive Hotel/Resort to Heritance Aarah Maldives, Leading Designer Hotel/Resort to Cocoon Maldives Maldives, Leading Wellness and Spa Hotel/Resort to Heritance Ayurveda Sri Lanka, Leading Business Hotel to Andaz Delhi, by Hyatt India (North), Leading Fine Dining Outlet in Hotel/Resort, Loya - Taj West End, Bengaluru India (South), Leading Riverfront Hotel/Resort, Le Méridien Paro, Riverfront Bhutan, Leading Airport Hotel to Hulhule Island Hotel Maldives, Leading Palace Hotel to Rambagh Palace India (North), Leading Surf Hotel/Resort to Cinnamon Dhonveli Maldives, Leading Dive Hotel/Resort to Adaaran Club Rannalhi Maldives, Leading Convention Center award to Uday Palace Convention Centre India (South), Leading Wildlife Lodge, Tented

SATA Awards 2025



Photo Collection



Kingsbury Colombo



OFFICIAL HOST

Cinnamon
GRAND
Colombo



Aitken Spence receiving Awards

Hayleys Travels



SOUTH ASIAN TRAVEL AWARDS - FOR SRI LANKAN MEDIA

The 9th edition of the South Asian Travel Awards – SATA 2025, recognized all Media Brands in South Asia for their contributions towards uplifting the tourism industry in the region, while 7 brands were honored in Sri Lanka.

They were StarMedia (Print & Online publisher & Public Relations & Media Event Solutions Provider), NewsLanka (Lankapuvath International News Agency), Lanka TOURGUIDE' sustainable tourism promotional print and online news magazine of Sri Lanka, Alliance of Tourism Journalists, (The Travel Journalists association of South Asia), Travel Talk Sri Lanka – the Travel Magazine, Aviation Voice' Sri Lanka's Premier Aviation News Portal. Sameer Yunoos, Vice President SATA Sri Lanka presented the accolades at Cinnamon Grand Colombo on September 19.



Thank You!

Thank you SATA, for your recognition

Camp to Cinnamon Wild Yala Sri Lanka, Leading Passenger Sales Agent (PSA) won by Villa Travels & Tours (Pvt) Ltd Maldives, Leading General Sales Agent (GSA) to Ace Aviation Services Maldives, Leading Supervision Agent (General Aviation Service) to Avia Maldives, Leading Cruise Travel Agent award to Aitken Spence Travels Sri Lanka, Leading Tourist Transport Provider (Air) Gold Award received by Trans Maldivian Airways (Pvt) Ltd Maldives, Leading Liveaboard to Maldives Legend Maldives, Leading Liveaboard Brand to Voyages Maldives, Leading International Airline to SriLankan Airlines Sri Lanka,

Visitors Choice Awards were presented to the following; Leading Adventure Destination is Maldives, Leading Heritage Destination is Bhutan, Leading MICE Destination is Sri Lanka, Leading Wellness Destination is Sri Lanka.

Sameer Yoonus Vice President SATA (Sri Lanka) together with SATA Chairman Ismail Hameed presented appreciation awards to the local media. Among them were StarMedia (Public Relations & Media Event Solutions), NewsLanka (Lankapuvath International News Agency), Lanka TOURGUIDE' sustainable tourism promotional print and online news magazine of Sri Lanka, Alliance of Tourism Journalists, (The Travel Journalists association of Sri Lanka), Travel Talk Asia – popular Travel Magazine of Sri Lanka, Aviation Voice' Sri Lanka's Premier Aviation News Portal.

These awards represent not only operational excellence but also the innovation and cultural richness that define South Asian tourism.

SATA Connect & Conversation (C&C) networking event was held on Friday 19, where industry leaders shared insights on the evolving tourism landscape and the main event where top performers and stakeholders were honored for their contributions to the industry. South Asian hospitality leaders urged regional collaboration to elevate South Asian Tourism. A powerful and unified call for greater regional collaboration to position South Asia as a premier global travel destination was the central theme at the "Connect & Conversations" forum, held at the Cinnamon Grand Colombo as a component of the South Asian Travel Awards (SATA) 2025. The event brought together top tourism officials and industry leaders who advocated for a shift from competition to partnership. This vision of a unified tourism front was strongly supported by leaders from across the region.

Buddhika Hewawasam, Chairman of the Sri Lanka Tourism Authority (SLTDA), highlighted the immediate potential for synergistic partnerships, using the relationship between Sri Lanka and the Maldives as a prime example.

Setting the tone for the day, Suraj Khan, Vice President – SATA India, emphasized the objective. "Collectively in South Asia, on this platform, we can exchange a lot of ideas. This is all about how we can collaborate and make our industry and hospitality on a global level.

The goal is to make South Asia actually the finest travel region in the world." he said. Echoing this sentiment, Abdulla Ghiyas, Chairman of Visit Maldives Corporation, made a compelling case for a strategic alliance. "We must stop seeing each other as competitors and instead act as partners, sharing best practices and even case studies that can benefit us all," Ghiyas urged. He called for tangible joint initiatives like regional visas and shared marketing platforms to capitalize on the global economic shift towards Asia, ensuring the region's collective growth.

Cinnamon Grand Colombo also hosted the SATA 2025 Press Conference and a panel discussion on "The Future of Hospitality: Experiences, Technology & Revenue Management," featuring its General Manager, Nazoomi Azhar.

SATA extends heartfelt gratitude to its valued sponsors and partners, whose support has made this celebration of excellence possible. Destination Partner: Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA), Host Hotel: Cinnamon Grand Colombo, Platinum Partner: Honda Marine Maldives, Gold Partners: The Hawks Pvt Ltd, Velana International Airport, Allied Insurance Company of the Maldives, Silver Partners: Bizspoke, Renaatus, Airline Partner: SriLankan Airlines These awards, determined by global travellers, serve as a powerful endorsement of the country's diverse offerings and service excellence.

In a unique tribute to the SATA award, a ceremonial boat delivered the trophy down the Mahaweli river, honoring Cinnamon Citadel Kandy's distinction as the South Asian region's premier riverfront destination.

SATA GALA AWARDS CEREMONY At Cinnamon Grand Colombo



Above: THASL CEO Amal Goonetilleke (Centre) accepting the awards From SATA Vice Presidents Tuan Vaffooron (Left) and Sameer Yoonus (Right). Photo Below Kamal Munasinghe, COO Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts receiving the Award from Suraj Khan (Right) Vice President – SATA (India)



Best General Manager - Hospitality Industry Award

Ismail Hameed, President of the South Asian Travel Awards (SATA), noted that Sri Lankan stakeholders of the tourism industry, winning Silver and Gold awards at SATA 2025 is a testament to Sri Lanka's high standards and exceptional service. The statement refers to the 9th edition of the South Asian Travel Awards (SATA), hosted by Cinnamon Grand Colombo.

Hameed issued a special statement to the SATA supplement of 'The Sunday Island' congratulating Sri Lankan properties and services for their success at the 9th edition of the SATA 2025 gala event held in Colombo. He congratulated Sri Lankan winners, highlighting their high standards and exceptional service as a reflection of the nation's hospitality. He also acknowledged the efforts of all participants and winners in recognizing the best of South Asian hospitality and expressed appreciation for all participants and the winners.

Ismail Hameed, as the founder and president of SATA, has made a significant effort to elevate the hospitality industry in the region. SATA recognizes and celebrates the achievements of stakeholders across South Asia and has played a key role in setting higher standards for service quality, customer satisfaction, and innovation in the tourism and hospitality sector. The awards have received endorsements from numerous industry organizations, highlighting their importance in promoting and uplifting the industry across countries like The Maldives, Sri Lanka, India, Nepal, Bhutan and Bangladesh.

Hameed and his team of Highrise Pvt Ltd based in Male, has successfully positioned SATA as a premier event for the region's travel and hospitality industry. "SATA's objective is to recognize and reward the exceptional performance of companies and individuals in the South Asian hospitality sector, encouraging them to achieve greater excellence" said Hameed.

Since its inception in 2016, SATA has grown into one of the most influential brands in the region, endorsed by leading regional and international tourism bodies. The awards program continues to serve as a platform for nations to come together, not in competition, but in celebration of shared triumphs and brilliance.

The SATA Gala event brought together key players from South Asia and has secured support and partnerships with various influential bodies, including state owned organisations. Sri Lanka Tourism Promotion Bureau (SLTPB) and Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA) as state owned partners while the Sri Lanka Association of Inbound Tour Operators (SLAITO) and the Hotels Association of Sri Lanka (THASL) partnering as leading private

sector organizations engaged in the tourism industry. Large organisations in the region such as "Incredible India" and Travel Agents Association of India (TAAI) are also contributing partners. SATA initiative has received endorsements from over 15 international and government agencies that has underscored its importance in developing the tourism industry across South Asia.

Cinnamon Hotels Records Eight Awards

Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts received a record eight awards. 2025, including multiple Gold and Silver honors for its properties in Sri Lanka and the Maldives. The accolades recognized excellence in categories like Leading Eco-Friendly Hotel (Gold), Leading Wildlife Tented Lodge (Gold), Leading Wedding Destination Hotel (Gold), and Signature Selection (Silver). Key wins included Gold for Cinnamon Dhonveli Maldives (Leading Surf Resort), Cinnamon Velifushi Maldives (Leading Beach Resort), Cinnamon Lodge Habarana (Leading Eco-Friendly Hotel/Resort), Cinnamon Wild Yala (Leading Wildlife Tented Lodge/Resort), and Cinnamon Lakeside Colombo (Leading Wedding Destination Hotel). The group also won a special recognition award for Kamal Munasinghe (General Manager of the Year

Aitken Spence receives three Awards

Aitken Spence Hotels was recognised with three distinguished accolades at the South Asian Travel Awards (SATA) 2025 Gala Ceremony and this year reaffirmed the group's diverse strengths across different facets of tourism.

Heritage Aarah was named Leading All-Inclusive Resort, a recognition of the resort's ability to offer guests a seamless, thoughtfully curated holiday experience. With its blend of exceptional service, world-class dining, and immersive leisure opportunities, the resort continues to define what it means to deliver a premium all-inclusive escape in the Maldives. Adaaran Club Rannalhi received the title of Leading Dive Hotel/Resort, reflecting its reputation as a sought-after destination for diving enthusiasts. Situated amidst some of the Maldives' most vibrant marine environments, the resort offers guests both accessibility and expertise, making it an ideal choice for those wishing to explore the region's underwater wonders responsibly and safely. Heritage Ayurveda was awarded Leading Wellness & Spa Hotel/Resort, in recognition of its commitment to authentic wellness experiences rooted in Sri Lanka's ancient healing traditions. The resort's focus on holistic ayurvedic care, combined with modern comforts, has made it a trusted sanctuary for travelers seeking rejuvenation and balance.



SATA Chief Lauds Sri Lanka's Hospitality Industry for Performance Excellence

Spence Hotels serve as an acknowledgment of the group's ongoing commitment to shaping hospitality that is distinctive, guest-centered, and rooted in the unique strengths of its destinations.

The Kingsbury Colombo as Leading F&B Hotel

At the 2025 South Asian Travel Awards (SATA), Hayleys Leisure won three awards: Gold for The Kingsbury Colombo as Leading F&B Hotel, Gold for Amaya Lake as Leading Family Resort, and Silver for Amaya Resorts & Spas as Leading Resort Brand in South Asia. These accolades acknowledge Hayleys Leisure's excellence in food and beverage, family-friendly offerings, and overall regional hospitality brand presence.

SriLankan the leading Airlines

SriLankan Airlines was named the Leading International Airline in South Asia. This recognition, determined by votes from both industry professionals and passengers, reinforces the airline's status and its commitment to customer satisfaction. SriLankan Airlines has a consistent history of winning at the SATA awards, showing continued strength in the South Asian market. The airline won the Gold Award for "Leading International Airline - South Asia" for the second consecutive year. They secured two titles at SATA 2023 held in Bangalore.



Suresh Abbas

"Lavishly enjoy a magnificent, high-end experience directly on the coast. It is about embracing an extravagant and luxurious seaside fun, going beyond basic comfort to experience the absolute best the location has to offer" - Abbas.

Sri Lanka's revered oceanfront luxury heritage hotel will play host to a new era of fun, refinement and entertainment by bringing back the "mambo" as the dance movement is set to once again shake the city and its hotel guests.

King of the Mambo, a Cuban restaurant and bar at the Galle Face Hotel, has re-launched with a new vibe, food, and entertainment, while customer reviews on many sites are praising its atmosphere and beachfront location.

King of the Mambo is recommended for a chill night out with friends, enjoying the cocktails and vibrant atmosphere, especially at sunset.

Recent positive reviews mention friendly staff and a great atmosphere. Its location at the historic Galle Face Hotel is a major draw, offering beautiful ocean views.

"This is the closest beachfront vibrant hotspot of the city coastal line" said Suresh Abbas General Manager Galle Face Hotel. The venue is described as vibrant and lively, with a beachfront setting and a Cuban-inspired theme featuring live music and dancing, with a calendar of themed nights and events.

The restaurant re-launched in April 2025, signaling a new chapter for the venue. It is ideal for a relaxed, fun-filled evening, but be aware that the food quality may vary, so it small bites rather than a formal dinner.

EXCLUSIVE CUBAN RESTAURANT IN COLOMBO

**Drink, Dine Dance
to the beat of the
Mambo!**



Colombo's top destination for Cuban dining, beachfront drinks, and vibrant nightlife at the iconic Galle Face Hotel.

Live the Beat of Havana in Colombo King of the Mambo is Colombo's premier Cuban restaurant and beachfront bar, located along the legendary Galle Face hotel. King of the Mambo blends the bold flavors of Latin America with the laid-back rhythm of island life.

"Step inside and you'll find more than just a place to dine — you'll discover a vibrant cultural experience. With colorful Havana-inspired interiors, tropical cocktails, and live Cuban music, King of the Mambo offers a one-of-a-kind escape in the heart of Sri Lanka's capital. Whether you're joining us for sunset cocktails, a romantic dinner by the sea, or a night of dancing, we serve up an unforgettable mix of great food, rhythm, and atmosphere - Buen Provecho!" said Suresh Abbas GM Galle Face Hotel.



Beachside lunch or a festive night out, food is designed to be shared, savored, and remembered.

As the Cuban-inspired restaurant at Galle Face Hotel, King of the Mambo adds a bold and flavorful twist to the hotel's legacy — combining Latin spirit with Colombo's coastal charm.

At King of the Mambo, every moment tells a story — of flavor, rhythm, and coastal soul. Set against the stunning backdrop of Colombo's Galle Face beachfront, our venue captures the essence of Cuban culture through vibrant food, handcrafted cocktails, live Latin music, and golden sunsets.

Whether it's the sizzle of Cuban street food, the sparkle of a mojito glass at golden hour, or the pulse of the dance floor under the stars, every image reflects the energy we live by.

Scroll through and experience Colombo's most colorful dining destination — where Cuban cuisine, Caribbean cocktails, and a world-class seaside setting come together in perfect harmony.



Experience the Art of Cuban Mixology in Colombo. At King of the Mambo, cocktails aren't just drinks — they're an experience. Our bar brings the spirit of Havana to Colombo, serving up a bold collection of

Cuban classics, tropical infusions, and house-crafted signatures.

From the timeless mojito and refreshing daiquiri to tropical blends bursting with island flavors, each cocktail is made to complement the rhythm of the sea and the beat of the night. Whether you're lounging by the ocean or dancing under the stars, our drinks set the mood.

Crafted with premium spirits, fresh herbs, and exotic ingredients, our cocktail menu the perfect pairing for sunset views, Latin music, and unforgettable nights at Colombo's favorite beachfront bar.

A Taste of Cuba in the Heart of Colombo Discover the bold, soulful flavors of authentic Cuban cuisine right here in Colombo. At King of the Mambo, our menu brings the heat and heart of Havana to the Galle Face shoreline, with dishes inspired by traditional Cuban recipes, Latin street food, and vibrant Caribbean spices. Think spice-kissed meats, vibrant tacos, grilled seafood, and creamy, comforting sides—all crafted with fresh, locally-sourced ingredients. Perfect for a laid-back





The Perfect Family Escape



Cinnamon Bey is widely considered a great getaway for families due to its kid-friendly amenities, spacious grounds, and beachfront location. Cinnamon Bey has a dedicated kids' pool and a kids' club with a variety of fun daily activities, a play area, and even PlayStation games for older children. They also offer babysitting services upon request. The resort offers multiple dining options, including a buffet at the main restaurant, Bufe, which is praised for its wide selection that appeals to children and adults. The onsite Ice Cream Emporium, ICE, is also a hit with kids. The property is spacious with large lawns and direct access to a protected beach, which is ideal for families with young children.

Cinnamon Bey Beruwala offers a solid, family-friendly resort experience, especially for those seeking a tropical getaway with child-oriented facilities. The kids' club, pool, and beachfront location provide plenty to keep children

entertained. Cinnamon Bey is a family-friendly hotel directly on the beach with spacious lawns, a large central pool, and a kids' pool. Deluxe Pool Terrace rooms offer easy access directly to the swimming pool. Many guests find the resort to be family-friendly, with safe beach access protected by a coral reef and spacious rooms that can accommodate families. Numerous family reviews praise the staff for being attentive, friendly, and accommodating, especially toward families with children. The hotel is a convenient base for family excursions to nearby attractions like the Kosgoda Turtle Hatchery, where kids can see baby turtles, and the Galle Fort.

PERFECT GETAWAY FOR FAMILIES



Cinnamon Bey Beruwala is a state of the art getaway, placing the grandeur of a city hotel one hour away from Colombo. A luxurious and tranquil beachfront hotel in Sri Lanka, the Cinnamon Bey Beruwala hotel is a charming property with a relaxed ambience and striking sea views. Fusing modern luxuries with classic Asian heritage, guests will experience the best of both worlds here. Cinnamon Bey along Beruwala is one of the largest resorts in the southern coastline. Its rich and diverse offerings make the entire resort a big

experience from 6 specialized dining options to 200 rooms and grand Turkish theme.

The uniqueness of Cinnamon Bey Beruwala lies in its combination of modern luxury, extensive dining options, and a strong commitment to sustainability. Compared to many luxury beach resorts that focus solely on opulence, Cinnamon Bey differentiates itself by integrating sustainable, eco-conscious practices and providing exclusive, personalized experiences.

Sustainable Luxury

Cinnamon Bey stands out for its deep commitment to sustainability, which is woven into its operations and design. LEED Gold Certification: The hotel was the first in Sri Lanka to achieve LEED V-2009 Gold certification for its green standards, which guide its construction and operations.

Eco-friendly operations: The resort uses 100% energy-efficient LED lighting, harnesses solar power for hot water, and implements extensive water-saving measures like rainwater harvesting and wastewater treatment for irrigation.



Conservation initiatives: The resort actively participates in marine conservation, including a coral restoration project on the Beruwala Reef. It also helps preserve the local environment through regular beach cleanups.

Cinnamon Bey goes beyond offering a typical beach holiday by integrating Sri Lankan culture and heritage into the guest experience. The hotel's restaurants incorporate authentic local ingredients and dishes, ensuring guests experience the island's unique cuisine.

The large buffet is frequently mentioned, with guests enjoying the wide selection of food, including local Sri Lankan dishes. The dessert and pastry options are also highlighted as a particular treat.

Due to the hotel's large size, the main buffet restaurant can feel crowded, especially during peak times and the section to the beachfront is narrow and since the beach is public there can be a little disturbance. However, the property can be described as a visually stunning, sprawling resort ideal for a relaxing getaway. Overall, the hotel receives positive ratings for its beachfront location and large pools, with a mixed but often positive reception for its food. The excellent food and friendly staff are often highlights. For the most consistently high-quality experience, guests frequently recommend booking a deluxe room.

food quality can be inconsistent, occasionally being too salty or not meeting the expected 5-star standard. Crowded main dining area: Due to the hotel's large size, the main buffet restaurant can feel crowded, especially during peak times.

Limited beach access and quality: Some reviewers mention that while the hotel is on the beach, the section directly in front of the property is narrow or not ideal for lounging. Other reviews mention that the beach is public and can get crowded.

Salty tap water: A few guests have commented that the tap water in the rooms can have a salty taste, which is unpleasant for brushing teeth or bathing.

Overall guest consensus

Overall, guests describe Cinnamon Bay as a visually stunning, sprawling resort ideal for a relaxing getaway. The excellent food and friendly staff are often highlights. However, expectations for a modern, perfectly maintained resort should be tempered by the feedback that some parts of the property are aging. For the most consistently high-quality experience, guests frequently recommend booking a deluxe room.



Paradise Suite - Living Room



Deluxe Room - Bathroom



Deluxe Room - Bedroom



Cinnamon Colombo Hotels Initiate the Christmas Festive



18th & 19th October-Kandy

Cinnamon Citadel has scheduled something's brewing in Kandy...

The laughter, the rhythm, and the spirit of celebration are making their way back to Cinnamon Citadel Kandy. ❄️

Save the Date - 18th & 19th October 2025 to celebrate the Season with annual Christmas Cake Mixing Ceremony, where guests will savor the treats and enjoy the camaraderie of the festive gathering.

<https://web.facebook.com/CinnamonCitadelKandy/videos/2364316927319994/>

Cinnamon Grand Colombo and Cinnamon Lakeside Colombo Hosted Annual Cake Mixing Ceremony is an annual event that marks the official start of the festive season. The ceremonies were held with the presence of respective General Managers Dushyantha Tittawella (Cinnamon Lakeside), Nazoomi Azhar (Cinnamon Grand), Terrence Fernando (Cinnamon Red) with their Management and Staff along with Customers.

They were all mixing the ingredients for the Christmas cake, symbolizing the spirit of Christmas and togetherness.

This event sets the stage for a season of celebration and holiday cheer at the hotel. Cinnamon hotels Colombo marked the official start of the holiday season with its much-anticipated Annual Cake Mixing Ceremony. Speaking at the occasion, Mr. Nazoomi Azhar, General Manager of Cinnamon Grand Colombo, highlighted the significance of the tradition "The Cake Mixing Ceremony is more than a festive ritual; it is a celebration of heritage, community, and the joy of the season. With this year's theme, we sought to capture the warmth and nostalgia that make Christmas truly special.

"At Cinnamon Grand, we take pride in blending tradition with innovation to create memorable experiences for our guests" said Azhar.

Dushyantha Thithawella, General Manager of Cinnamon Lakeside toasted to a spectacular Christmas. His speech set the tone for the celebrations, delivering an exceptional holiday experience for guests. He announced the official start of the festive season.

Eagerly awaited annual highlight, the Cake Mixing Ceremony underscored the role of Cinnamon Hotels as a curator of unique culinary traditions and festive celebrations. Beyond the ritual, it reaffirms the hotel's reputation for culinary excellence and hospitality that resonates with both local and international guests.

The 2025 ceremony also signals the beginning of Cinnamon City hotels festive offerings, with an array of signature Christmas cakes, hampers, and gourmet delights available across the hotel's outlets throughout the holiday season.



Cinnamon Grand Colombo ceremony showcased the artistry of the hotel's award winning culinary brigade, led by Executive Chef Kapila Jayasinghe.



It's beginning to feel a lot like Christmas. Get ready to be merry. Eat and drink

Thai Boulevard, Colombo's much-loved destination for authentic Thai dining, marks a milestone this year as it celebrates its 10th anniversary with a stunning new look. Following an extensive refurbishment, the restaurant has reopened recently with a fresh, contemporary look infused with Thai-inspired art and design elements, offering guests a vibrant yet elegant setting to savour the best of Thai cuisine.

"Reaching our tenth anniversary is a proud moment for us. The renovated spaces represents our commitment to giving our guests not only the authentic flavours they have loved over the years, but also a refreshed, stylish atmosphere that makes every visit memorable" said Kanthi Jayamaha Chairperson of Thai Boulevard and Tasty Caterers. She went on to say, *"We're excited to continue this journey with the same culinary team and look forward to welcoming both loyal and new diners to experience the next chapter of Thai Boulevard."*

The restaurant now accommodates up to 100 guests, including three private dining rooms ideal for intimate celebrations and events, catering for groups between 10 and 32 people. Behind the kitchen doors, the trusted duo of a Thai chef and Sri Lankan chef—who have been with Thai Boulevard since its inception—continue to lead the culinary team. Staying true to its philosophy, the menu retains its most popular favourites while introducing several new dishes to enhance the overall offering to its loyal patrons and first-time guests alike. Among the highlights of the new additions to the menu are the Spicy prawn salad with pomelo, Thai chicken dumpling salad, Stir-fried belly pork with crispy shallots, garlic, and green chili, Yellow curry fish, Steamed whole garoupa in soy and ginger sauce and the Sizzling mixed seafood platters with Thai herbs

Thai Boulevard Celebrates ten Years of Authentic Thai Cuisine

or yellow curry to name a few. Guests can also enjoy an extensive selection of juices and mocktails, while those wishing to bring their own wine are welcome to do so—with no corkage charged.

With its new design, elevated dining spaces, and innovative dishes, Thai Boulevard continues to raise the bar for Thai cuisine in Sri Lanka, offering an experience that blends the best of Thai tradition, flavour, and modern style.



Unlike cuisines that focus on a single dominant flavor, Thai dishes use layers of taste to create a complex, nuanced, and memorable experience. Thai cooking is described as an art of "juggling" different elements—like pairing pungent herbs with spices or balancing salty sauces with sweet and acidic notes—to create a unified, harmonious finish. – Suranjith De Fonseka, Thai Boulevard.



Suranjith Kanthi and Chamindri

The uniqueness of Thai Food lies in its masterful balance of contrasting flavors of **4S**; Sweet, Sour, Salty, and Spicy—within a single dish, achieved through aromatic fresh herbs like lemongrass and galangal, ingredients such as fish sauce and chili, and traditional cooking techniques. This complexity, combined with regional diversity and the central role of rice and noodles, creates layered, harmonious dishes that are a distinctive experience from other cuisines.

Sri Lanka Showcases Tourism Potential at TTG in Italy



Sri Lanka made a strong presence at the TTG - Travel Experience 2025, Italy's leading international travel and tourism fair, held from 8 to 10 October 2025 at the Rimini Expo Centre. The Sri Lanka Tourism Promotion Bureau (SLTPB), in collaboration with the Consulate General of Sri Lanka in Milan, organized the country's participation, marking another significant step in strengthening Sri Lanka's visibility and partnerships in the Italian market.

The Sri Lanka pavilion drew significant interest during the exhibition, with 24 Destination Management Companies (DMCs) from Sri Lanka joining the national delegation to promote the country's wide range of tourism offerings—from wellness and cultural tourism to adventure, wildlife and experiential travel. The collective effort aimed to position Sri Lanka as a diverse, sustainable and high-value destination catering to the evolving preferences of Italian travellers.

Italy continues to be one of Sri Lanka's key source markets, showing a steady increase in arrivals in recent years. For the first three quarters of 2025, there is a record increase of 33% of tourist arrival from Italy compared to the similar period of 2024. This growth significantly surpasses the overall increase in tourist arrivals to the country, which stands at 16.2%. Participation in TTG 2025 thus served as a timely opportunity to reaffirm Sri Lanka's commitment to the Italian market and to rebuild strong B2B and media connections following The three-day event provided a valuable Asia. Organized for the 62nd time, TTG Travel Experience is Italy's premier B2B event for promoting global tourism. The event was officially inaugurated by the Italian Tourism Minister Daniela Santanché on the 8th of



platform for networking, partnership building and destination branding, with Sri Lanka's pavilion drawing a high level of interest from travel professionals seeking authentic, sustainable and experiential destinations in October, and she emphasized the strategic importance of tourism as an economic and social driver in any country. A significant number of qualified attendees was registered, with a 3% overall growth compared to the previous edition. It brought together 2700+ exhibiting brands, 1,000+ foreign buyers from 75 countries and 700+ Italian and foreign journalists to Rimini over the three days.

GOVERNMENT REVIEWS TOURISM PROGRESS

The Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA) organized a progress review meeting on provincial tourism development and coordination on October 17 at the Galle Face Hotel, Colombo. The meeting was attended by Hon. Ruwan Ranasinghe, Deputy Minister of Tourism. Mr. Dheera Hettiarachchi, Chairman, Sri Lanka Convention Bureau (SLCB) & Sri Lanka Institute of Tourism and Hotel Management (SLITHM), Governors and chief secretaries of provincial councils, senior ministry officials, provincial council representatives, and donor agencies also participated.

The discussions focused on strengthening coordination between the national and provincial levels to enhance tourism development across all provinces. Participants reviewed the progress of ongoing tourism initiatives, identified key challenges, and explored strategies for sustainable and inclusive tourism growth throughout the country.

During the session on the way forward with the provincial councils, a consultation was conducted on aligning provincial tourism development priorities with the national tourism policy and sustainability framework. The dialogue emphasized the need for a unified approach to planning, implementation, and monitoring of tourism activities to ensure consistency with national objectives.

Participants also discussed the promotion of lesser-known tourist attractions to diversify the tourism portfolio and create broader regional economic benefits. The importance of improving visitor facilities, introducing effective training and capacity development programs, and enhancing institutional coordination between the SLTDA and provincial councils was also highlighted.

The SLTDA assured its commitment to working closely with all stakeholders to promote balanced and sustainable tourism development across Sri Lanka, positioning the country as a leading destination offering authentic and regionally diverse experiences.

Press Release | Media Unit | Sri Lanka Tourism



VOYAGE SRI LANKA Unveils in Colombo

"VOYAGE SRI LANKA 2025" Maritime Conference unveils Blue Economy potential in Colombo.

The second edition of the maritime conference "VOYAGE SRI LANKA 2025," organized by the Sri Lanka Export Development Board (SLEDB) in collaboration with key stakeholders from the public and private sectors, was successfully held on October 16, 2025, at the Kingsbury Hotel, Colombo, with the participation of Hon. Sunil Hadunnetti, Minister of Industry and Entrepreneurship Development.

Under the theme "Unlocking Sri Lanka's Blue Economy Potential," the conference aimed to highlight Sri Lanka's contribution to the Blue Economy and its potential as a global maritime hub.

The Chairman of the Sri Lanka Export Development Board stated that the SLEDB remains committed to fostering a globally competitive marine and offshore services sector by promoting innovation, human capital development, and international collaboration.

Addressing the "VOYAGE SRI LANKA 2025" maritime conference, Minister of Industry and Entrepreneurship Development Sunil Hadunnetti emphasized that Sri Lanka's geographic location is advantageous for the maritime industry. The Minister highlighted that infrastructure development plays a crucial role in leveraging this advantage.

He stated that the ministry is working on formulating necessary policies to achieve international competitiveness in the maritime industry. The Minister also invited international investors to invest in Sri Lanka's maritime sector, assuring that the Ministry of Industry will provide all necessary facilities and support. Dr. Anil Jayantha Fernando, Minister of Labor and Deputy Minister of Finance and Planning, delivered the keynote address on unlocking Sri Lanka's Blue

Economy through sustainable maritime Takafumi Kadono, Country Director of the investments and Asian Development Bank, spoke on ADB's strategic partnership in Sri Lanka's Blue Economy transformation, lessons learned, and future investment opportunities.

The conference was attended by Hon. Anura Karunatilaka, Minister of Ports and Civil Aviation; Hon. Chaturanga Abeysinghe Deputy Minister of Industry and Entrepreneurship; Development Ms. Tilaka Jayasundara, Secretary of the Ministry of Industry and Entrepreneurship Development; Mr. Hanif Yusoo, Governor of the Western Province; Mr. Arjuna Herath, Chairman, Board of Investment of Sri Lanka, Mr. Mangala Wijesinghe, Chairman and Chief Executive Officer of the Export Development Board; along with officials from the Export Development Board, heads of other institutions, industry leaders, partners, and a large number of delegates from Sri Lanka and overseas.

Representatives from the Ministry of Industry and Entrepreneurship Development, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Foreign Employment and Tourism, Sri Lanka Ports Authority, Board of Investment of Sri Lanka, Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority, Sri Lanka Navy, Marine Industry Council of Sri Lanka, Colombo Dockyard, and GAC Group Sri Lanka participated in the conference.

International development partners including the Asian Development Bank (ADB), International Maritime Organization (IMO), and United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), as well as academic experts from the University of Moratuwa and University of Ruhuna and local and international experts participated as resource persons at the event.

The conference was supported by Lanka Marine Services, Seylan Bank PLC, Lanka IOC PLC, Hayleys Advantis Limited, the Marine Industry Council of Sri Lanka, and the Sri Lanka Tourism Promotion Bureau as sponsors of the programme.

Press Release | Export Development Board

HAYLEYS LEISURE SHINES AT THE SOUTH ASIAN TRAVEL AWARDS 2025



The Kingsbury, Colombo - Gold Award

Taking centre stage, The Kingsbury, Colombo earned Gold for Leading F&B Hotel, reinforcing its position as South Asia's culinary icon.

Amaya Lake, Dambulla followed with Gold for Leading Family Resort, a tribute to its growing appeal as a serene escape in Sri Lanka's Cultural Triangle.

Adding to this success, Amaya Resorts & Spas received the Silver Award for Leading Resort Brand in South Asia, affirming its emergence as one of South Asia's most preferred family hospitality brands.

The Kingsbury Colombo, Amaya Lake, and Amaya Resorts & Spas brought home top honours at this year's South Asian Travel Awards (SATA), the region's most prestigious celebration of tourism and hospitality excellence.

Since its inception in 2016, SATA has become South Asia's foremost platform for recognising excellence in travel and hospitality. Against this competitive backdrop, Hayleys Leisure's wins epitomise its leadership, passion and commitment to delivering experiences that embody the true spirit of Sri Lankan hospitality.



Amaya Lake, Dambulla - Gold Award



Amaya Resorts & Spas - Silver Award